

A long time ago, Meira Kumar had written a poem about a Dalit woman called Shabri who swept floors, washed dirty dishes and did all kinds of menial work—unappreciated. Today, as the country's first woman Speaker of the Lok Sabha, Babu Jagjivan Ram's daughter is now in the business of scripting history, and with a lot more appreciation than poor Shabri. Her elevation is akin to pulling a political rabbit out of a hat. Having first sworn in the 64-year-old Kumar as a non-glamorous water resources minister, the Congress leadership did a rethink and decided instead to project her as the country's first woman Speaker. The prime minister called it a historic moment. It's also a smart move. Earlier, it was the BJP that planned to nominate a woman to the post of Deputy Speaker while the Congress let it be known that its choice was the erudite Kishore Chandra Deo, a tribal from Andhra Pradesh. At that time, the BJP had zeroed in on the matronly Sumitra Mahajan from Indore.

Then the Congress played its trump card. That Kumar is also a Dalit made the choice all the more politically correct. As a gleeful Congress general secretary said, "This will trump Mayawati's projection of herself as a *Dalit ki beti*" (Dalit's daughter). Interestingly, Kumar won her first election from Bijnore in Uttar Pradesh in a bypoll where she defeated two Dalit icons, Mayawati and Ram Vilas Paswan. The new Speaker is sticking to the party script. "Two years ago we chose the first woman President. Now, too, we have shown that we don't believe in mere symbolic gestures," she said in her opening speech. UPA chairperson Sonia Gandhi beamed in approval, as did all the 58 women MPs in the Lok Sabha. For a House that refuses to pass the Women's Reservation Bill, it was symbolism at its best.

To counter this rather blatant attempt at social engineering, the BJP too has done a rethink and nominated a tribal from Jharkhand, Karia Munda, as Deputy Speaker. Ironically, while Kumar's elevation is not without its triumph for Bihar, it has left the state unrepresented in Manmohan's council of ministers at a time when it is next on Rahul Gandhi's revival agenda after Uttar Pradesh.

Two years ago, the United States elected its first woman speaker of the House of Representatives. But the soft-spoken Kumar, who prefers historic biographies to racy fiction, is no Nancy Pelosi. The last Lok Sabha lost 423

hours of Parliament time to disruptions even with a stalwart like Somnath Chatterjee at the helm. "I have some very tall shoes to fill," says Kumar. Her reputation as an ace shooter may help. Replying to a question that has never been posed to any of her predecessors, she said, "I don't cry. Like everybody, I do get angry, but I never cry." The voice is sing-song but the notes are definitely sharp.

This destiny's child has little to cry about. Her association with the Nehru-Gandhis dates back to when she was a toddler accompanying her father to Teen Murti Bhavan to meet Jawaharlal Nehru. Later, in 1985, Rajiv Gandhi persuaded the young IFS officer to reclaim her father's legacy. Since then, the five-term MP has contested elections from Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Delhi. Initially, when Sonia took over as party chief in 1999, Kumar felt neglected and left the Congress, only to return in 2002. She had said that she quit because the Congress was neglecting the weaker sections. She has little to complain now.

Her previous stint in Manmohan's ministry was a lacklustre affair except for a brief spell when she emerged as the champion of reservations. She quotes the story of Eklavya from the *Mahabharata* to buttress her point in favour of the socially and economically oppressed.

Despite the starched pastel sari demeanour, the new Speaker knows how to unwind. At her granddaughter Anahita's first birthday party, which was a fancy dress event, she surprised guests by wearing a turban and painting on a beard. In the end, it was her distinctive voice that gave her away. It's a family that not just parties together but works

together too. Corporate lawyer and husband Manjul Kumar is her campaign manager. A former diplomat and Delhi University graduate, Kumar has both an LL.B and an advanced diploma in Spanish.

Her house in Delhi's posh Maharani Bagh reflects her eclectic taste. The tribal art on the wall is son Anshul's collection but the orchids and the enthuriums in the balcony are Kumar's passion. The rug on the floor was a gift to her father from the Shah of Iran. However, she will need more of her diplomatic skills to keep the Lok Sabha in order. Judging by Somnath's agony, she may have to lose some of her demure demeanour and borrow a little of her predecessor's intimidating ways. Maybe it's time for another change of fancy dress.

with Amitabh Srivastava

“It's a historic occasion as for the first time a woman has been elected Speaker, and that too a Dalit.”

MANMOHAN SINGH, prime minister



MANMOHAN FELICITATES KUMAR (LEFT) AFTER HER ELECTION AS SPEAKER